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Encrypt

Most people who use computers, and that includes members of the Fourth Estate, think there's a fourth basic permission besides Read, Write, and Execute, called "Delete."

Delete is everywhere on the user side of computing. It's in the hardware as a key on the keyboard, and it's in the software as an option that can be chosen from a drop-down menu. There's a certain finality that comes with choosing Delete, and a certain sense of responsibility. Sometimes a box even pops up to double-check: "Are you sure?" If the computer is second-guessing you by requiring confirmation—click "Yes"—it makes sense that Delete would be a consequential, perhaps even the ultimate decision.

Undoubtedly, that's true in the world outside of computing, where the powers of deletion have historically been vast. Even so, as countless despots have been reminded, to truly get rid of a document you can't just destroy every copy of it. You also have to destroy every memory of it, which is to say you have to destroy all the people who remember it, along with every copy of all the other documents that mention it and all the people who remember all those other documents. And then, maybe, just maybe, it's gone.

Delete functions appeared from the very start of digital computing. Engineers understood that in a world of effectively unlimited options, some choices would inevitably turn out to be mistakes. Users, regardless of whether or not they were really in control at the technical level, had to *feel* in control, especially with regard to anything that they themselves had created. If they made a file, they should be able to unmake it at will. The ability to destroy what they created and start over afresh was a primary function that imparted a sense of agency to the user, despite the fact that they might be dependent on proprietary hardware they couldn't repair and software they couldn't modify, and bound by the rules of third-party platforms.